

Roman Seven Sacrament System Denial

doc-roman-seven-sacrament-system-denial

Sacraments · Number and Nature · doctrine · divided_lineages

DISPUTED

score 0.750
confidence medium

Statement under examination

Christ explicitly instituted two ordinances for the Church (baptism and the Lord's Supper); other rites later identified as sacraments lack explicit dominical institution.

In plain language

The proposition makes two claims at once, and the Greek text treats them differently. The first claim is that Jesus himself set up two practices, baptism and the Lord's Supper, with a clear command. This is strongly supported. In Matthew 28:19 the risen Jesus says *matheteusate*, make disciples, a command form, *baptizontes*, baptizing them into the triune name. In Luke 22:19 and again twice in 1 Corinthians 11:24 and 25 he says *touto poieite*, do this, a command form, for my remembrance, and the word for remembrance occurs only four times in the whole New Testament and clusters on exactly these Supper texts. Paul also frames the account with the technical words I received from the Lord and I delivered, the language of a fixed tradition traced to Christ. So baptism and the Supper each have a command spoken by the Lord, a prescribed sign, and an assigned meaning. The second claim is harder. The proposition also says the other rites later called sacraments are not really sacraments, that the count of seven is wrong. Here the words leave room. The verses behind the other five rites do contain real instructions. John 20:23, spoken by Jesus, grants a forgiveness commission, though as a condition, not a do this. James 5:14 has elders anoint the sick with oil. James 5:16 commands confess your sins to one another, a present command, but mutual rather than clergy-run. The laying on of hands for commissioning appears at 1 Timothy 4:14, Acts 13:3, and 1 Timothy 5:22 as a frequent practice. Marriage is called a great mystery in Ephesians 5:32, but that word everywhere else means a revealed secret, not a rite. So all five have a footing in the text as practices. What the words do not settle is whether lacking a do this command from Jesus means they are not sacraments, because that depends on what you mean by the word sacrament, and the Greek never defines the category. That is why this lands as disputed: the institution facts are clear, but the count is a definitional question the vocabulary underdetermines. Confidence is medium.

Word dictionary

Every Hebrew and Greek word this study leans on, in everyday terms. Shaded rows are the anchor words the verdict rests on.

Strong	Word	Sounds like	Plain meaning	Times in Bible
G0218	ἀλείψαντες	aleiphō	to anoint	
G0364	ἀνάμνησις	anamnesis	remembrance	4
G0740	ἄρτος	artos	bread	99
G0863	ἀφῆτε	aphiēmi	to release	
G0907	βαπτίζω	baptizo	to baptize	82
G1242	διαθήκη	diatheke	covenant	33
G1843	ἐξομολογέω	exomologeō	to agree	10
G2007	ἐπιτίθημι	epitithēmi	to put/lay on	39

G2168	εὐχαριστέω	eucharisteō	to thank	
G2537	καινός	kainos	new	
G2806	κλάω	klao	to break	15
G3100	μαθητεύω	matheteuo	to disciple	4
G3466	μυστήριον	mysterion	mystery	30
G3860	παραδίδωμι	paradidomi	to deliver	123
G3880	παραλαμβάνω	paralambano	to take	51
G4160	ποιέω	poieo	to do/make	568
G4221	ποτήριον	poterion	cup	34
G4336	προσευξάσθωσαν	proseuchomai	to pray	
G5495	χειρῶν	cheir	hand	

Plain meanings: STEP Bible brief lexicons TBESH (Hebrew) and TBESG (Greek), CC BY 4.0. Counts are occurrences across the 66-book canon.

Verdict rationale

Variant-robust: True · Pan-canonical: False

Two distinct claims are fused in the proposition, and the lexical record ranks them differently. The narrow claim, that only baptism and the Supper carry an explicit Christ-spoken institution formula, is decisively supported: matheteusate G3100 is an aorist active imperative (V-AAM-2P) in Matt.28.19 governing the participle baptizantes G0907, and touto poieite G4160 is a present active imperative (V-PAM-2P) three times across Luke.22.19 and 1Cor.11.24-25, paired with anamnesis G0364, a word that occurs only four times and clusters on exactly these Supper texts. No other rite carries a Christ-spoken command plus prescribed sign of this form. But the broader claim that the count of seven is therefore false, that the other five are not sacraments, is a category judgment the vocabulary does not settle, because confession (exomologeisthe, a present imperative in Jas.5.16), anointing the sick (Jas.5.14), the laying on of hands for commissioning (1Tim.4.14, Acts.13.3, 1Tim.5.22), marriage (Eph.5.31-32), and the forgiveness commission (John.20.23) all have real New Testament footing as practices, and whether the absence of a dominical do this clause disqualifies them from the category sacrament depends on a definition of sacrament that the Greek does not supply. The institution observation is high-grade; the system-denial inference is underdetermined, so the verdict is disputed.

Scripture

Matt.28.19 · for · genre: gospel

Key terms. G3100 μαθητεύσατε, G0907 βαπτίζοντες

Force. The risen Christ issues matheteusate (G3100, parsed V-AAM-2P, aorist active imperative second plural, make disciples) which governs the present participle baptizantes (G0907, V-PAP-NPM, baptizing) into the triune name. This is a direct command spoken by the Lord that prescribes baptism as a standing action for all nations, the shape of an explicit institution. The dedicated water rite verb baptizo stands under the Lord's own imperative here, and baptizo recurs across the canon 82 times in 66 verses (Acts.2.38, Acts.8.12, 1Cor.1.13 and beyond), so the practice is densely attested, not a single isolated saying.

Luke.22.19 · for · genre: gospel

Key terms. G2806 ἐκλασεν, G4160 ποιείτε, G0364 ἀνάμνησιν

Force. Jesus takes bread, gives thanks, breaks it (eklasen, G2806, V-AAI-3S), and issues touto poieite (G4160, parsed V-PAM-2P, present active imperative second plural, do this) eis ten emen anamnesin (for my remembrance, anamnesis G0364). The imperative plus the explanatory remembrance clause is an institution formula: the Lord prescribes a repeated action and assigns its meaning. The noun anamnesis occurs only four times in the canon (here, 1Cor.11.24, 1Cor.11.25, and Heb.10.3), and the three memorial-of-Christ uses cluster on exactly the Supper, so the institution-meaning word is lexically localized to this rite.

Luke.22.20 · for · genre: gospel · figures: metaphor

Key terms. G4221 ποτήριον, G1242 διαθήκη

Force. The cup (poterion, G4221) after supper is named he kaine diatheke (the new covenant, kainos G2537 plus diatheke G1242) in Christ's blood, poured out for the addressees. The covenant-cup language binds the second element of the rite to the Lord's own words and to the covenant arc that diatheke carries across 30 verses, including the Sinai blood-of-the-covenant of Exod.24.8 invoked by the cross-reference. This completes the two-part institution of the Supper; no later-named rite receives this covenant-cup designation in the lexical record.

1Cor.11.23 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G3880 παρέλαβον, G3860 παρέδωκα

Force. Paul frames the Supper with the technical transmission pair parelabon apo tou kyriou (I received from the Lord, paralambano G3880) and paredoka (I delivered, paradidomi G3860), the standing formula for a fixed authoritative tradition traced to the Lord himself. Paul uses the same paralambano-paradidomi chain for the gospel itself in 1Cor.15.1-3, so the language marks the Supper as dominically grounded and handed on, not a later innovation. The same chain-of-custody is not supplied for any of the five contested rites.

1Cor.11.24 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G4160 ποιείτε, G0364 ἀνάμνησιν

Force. Paul reproduces the dominical imperative touto poieite (G4160, V-PAM-2P) eis ten emen anamnesin over the broken body, matching the operative clause of Luke.22.19 word for word. In the Byzantine and received text the verse also carries labete and phagete (G2983, G5315, both V-2AAM-2P, take, eat), reinforcing the imperative shape. The bread element is thereby doubly attested as instituted by the Lord in gospel and epistle.

1Cor.11.25 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G4160 ποιείτε, G1242 διαθήκη

Force. The cup saying repeats touto poieite (G4160, V-PAM-2P), hosakis ean pinete (as often as you drink, with pinete in the present subjunctive), again a dominical imperative governing the repetition, joined to the kaine diatheke (new covenant) formula. Across the two verses poieo as imperative occurs three times bound to bread and cup, giving the Supper a full institution profile: command, element, assigned meaning, and frequency.

1Cor.11.26 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G0740 ἄρτον, G4221 ποτήριον

Force. The closing clause makes eating the bread and drinking the cup a proclamation of the Lord's death achri hou elthe (until he comes, G2064 V-2AAS-3S), giving the rite a defined content and an eschatological terminus. This is the lexical profile of an instituted ongoing ordinance with a fixed sign, fixed meaning, and fixed duration, the same profile baptism shows and the profile the five contested rites do not display in the cited verses.

John.20.23 · complicates · genre: gospel

Key terms. G0863 ἀφήτε

Force. The forgiveness saying uses aphete (G0863, parsed V-2AAS-2P, aorist subjunctive, if you forgive) and apheowntai (perfect passive, they have been forgiven), set in a conditional an clause, not an imperative instituting a repeated rite. The words are spoken by Christ, which is significant, but they grant a forgiveness commission rather than prescribe a standing penitential action with matter and form, so they do not reproduce the touto poieite institution shape. This is the strongest lexical footing for treating absolution as dominical, and it complicates a flat two-only reading.

Jas.5.14 · complicates · genre: epistle

Key terms. G0218 αλείψαντες, G4336 προσευξάσθωσαν

Force. The anointing instruction has aleipsantes (G0218, AAP, having anointed) under the third-person imperatives proskalesastho (let him call) and proseuxasthosan (let them pray), addressed to the church elders, not a command spoken by Christ. It is a genuine apostolic-era prescription for the sick that gives anointing real New Testament footing as a practice, but it lacks the dominical do this form. Whether that absence excludes it from the category sacrament is a definitional question, so the verse limits a flat denial without instituting the rite in the Supper-baptism sense.

Jas.5.16 · complicates · genre: epistle

Key terms. G1843 ἐξομολογείσθε

Force. Confession is commanded by exomologeisthe (G1843, parsed V-PMM-2P, present imperative second plural, confess) allelois (to one another), a reciprocal mutual action joined to euesthe (pray for one another). This is a real standing command, but it is mutual and congregational rather than a clergy-administered rite instituted by Christ, and it is spoken by an apostle, not by the Lord. It gives confession lexical footing as a practice while not matching the dominical institution profile, which is exactly why the broader sacramental count is contested rather than settled by the words.

Eph.5.32 · complicates · genre: epistle

Key terms. G3466 μυστήριον

Force. Marriage is called a mega mysterion (G3466, great mystery) referred to Christ and the church. The word mysterion occurs 30 times across the canon and consistently means a revealed secret or the gospel disclosed (Matt.13.11, Eph.1.9, Col.1.26), never a technical cultic rite, so at the level of vocabulary mysterion does not by itself denote a sacrament. The surrounding verbs in Eph.5.31 are future indicatives describing marriage and Matt.19.6 has the aorist synezeuxen (God joined) with the third-person imperative me chorizeto (let not man separate), a creation ordinance rather than a Christ-instituted church rite. This complicates a denial only at the definitional level.

1Tim.4.14 · complicates · genre: epistle

Key terms. G2007 ἐπιθέσεως, G5495 χειρῶν

Force. Commissioning by the epithesis ton cheiron (the laying on of hands, epitithemi G2007 plus cheir G5495) is a real recurring apostolic practice, attested at Acts.13.3 (epithentes, having laid on), Acts.6.6 (epethekan, they laid on), and as Paul's imperative to Timothy in 1Tim.5.22 (epitithe, V-PAM-2S). The verb epitithemi occurs 39 times and cheir 180 times, so the practice is densely present, but it is performed and prescribed by apostles and elders, not instituted by a Christ-spoken do this with a fixed sign. It limits a flat two-only denial while not meeting the dominical institution test.

Cross references invoked

From	To	Source	Votes
Matt.28.19	Matt.3.16	tsk	1

Luke.22.20	Exod.24.8	tsk	1
1Cor.11.24	Exod.12.14	tsk	1
1Cor.11.24	1Cor.5.7	tsk	1
1Cor.11.23	1Cor.15.3	tsk	1
Luke.22.19	Luke.22.20	tsk	1

Complicating texts

John.20.23 · addressed

Examined directly in the lexical store. The verb *aphete* is V-2AAS-2P (aorist subjunctive) inside an an conditional, with the perfect passive *aphewntai*, so it is a forgiveness commission spoken by Christ, not a *touto poieite* institution of a repeated penitential rite with prescribed matter and form. It is the strongest dominical footing among the contested rites and is the reason the broader denial is disputed rather than settled, but on the words it does not reproduce the institution profile that baptism and the Supper show.

Jas.5.14 · addressed

Examined directly. The anointing participle *aleipsantes* (G0218) sits under third-person imperatives addressed to elders (*proseuxasthosan*), an apostolic prescription for the sick, not a command spoken by Christ. It gives unction genuine New Testament footing as a practice, so it limits a flat two-only reading, but it does not carry the dominical do this institution clause.

Jas.5.16 · addressed

Examined directly. Confession is a present imperative *exomologeisthe* (G1843, V-PMM-2P) but reciprocal (to one another) and apostolic in voice, not a Christ-instituted clergy rite. It is a real standing command, which is why categorizing it is a definitional question the vocabulary does not resolve.

Eph.5.32 · addressed

Examined directly. The word *mysterion* (G3466) here means revealed mystery, the sense it carries in all 30 canonical occurrences, and does not lexically denote a cultic rite; the verbs in Eph.5.31 and Matt.19.6 frame marriage as a creation ordinance with a prohibition on separation, not a Christ-instituted church rite. It complicates the denial only at the definitional level.

1Tim.4.14 · addressed

Examined directly along with Acts.13.3, Acts.6.6, and 1Tim.5.22. The laying on of hands (*epitithemi* G2007, *cheir* G5495) is a densely attested apostolic and elder practice, prescribed by Paul as an imperative to Timothy, but never instituted by a Christ-spoken do this with a fixed sign. It limits a flat two-only denial while not meeting the dominical institution test.

Concordance traversed

G3100, G0907, G4160, G0364, G3860, G3880, G1242, G4221, G0740, G2806, G2168, G2537, G2007, G5495, G3466, G1843, G0863, G0218

Variants

Verdict variant-sensitive: False · ECM status: ecm-shadow

All anchor verses are New Testament outside 3 John, so the ingested CBGM apparatus is not in scope (*not_in_ecm_scope* true in the bundle, *variant_units* empty). The known longer-and-shorter text question at Luke.22.19b-20 affects whether the second cup saying is present, but the parallel institution in 1Cor.11.24-25 carries the same *touto poieite* imperative independently, so the institution observation for the Supper holds on either reading. Apparatus sigla at Matt.28.19 and across 1Cor.11 touch word order and minor readings, none of which removes the institution imperatives, so the verdict is not variant sensitive.

Hermeneutics

Primary method. grammatico-historical

Frameworks in play. sacramentalism, ordinance_theology, covenant_theology

analogia scripturae invoked · progressive revelation factor

two-ordinance reading: affirms · On this lens a sacrament or ordinance requires a command spoken by Christ that prescribes both a sign and its meaning. Only baptism (matheteusate plus baptizontes in Matt.28.19) and the Supper (touto poieite three times in Luke.22.19 and 1Cor.11.24-25, with anamnesis and the new covenant cup) carry that exact formula. The five later-named rites lack a Christ-spoken do this with a fixed sign, so on this definition only two were explicitly instituted by the Lord and the seven-fold count is not warranted by the institution texts.

seven-rite sacramental reading: complicates · On this lens a sacrament need not have a verbatim dominical do this clause; it is sufficient that Scripture attests the rite as a grace-bearing church practice. The forgiveness commission spoken by Christ in John.20.23, the elder-administered anointing of Jas.5.14, the mutual confession commanded in Jas.5.16, the laying on of hands at 1Tim.4.14, Acts.13.3, and 1Tim.5.22, and the marriage mysticon of Eph.5.31-32 all have real New Testament footing. The vocabulary attests these practices but does not classify them, so a reader using a broader definition of sacrament is not contradicted by the words; the count turns on the definition, which is extra-lexical.

redemptive-historical: affirms · Read along the covenant arc, the Supper is tied to the kaine diatheke cup of Luke.22.20 and the Passover fulfillment of 1Cor.5.7 and Exod.12.14, and baptism enacts the discipling of the nations. The two instituted signs occupy a distinct covenant-sign slot that the contested rites do not occupy in the lexical data, which favors a two-sign reading, though it does not by itself adjudicate whether the other practices may still be called sacraments under a non-covenantal definition.

Analogia scripturae is load-bearing for the narrow institution claim: the gospel institution in Luke.22.19-20 read with the received-and-delivered formula of 1Cor.11.23-26 yields a doubly attested Supper, and Matt.28.19 supplies the baptism command. The divergence is not over what these verbs say but over the definition of the category sacrament, which the Greek lexicon does not fix, so the lenses agree on the institution facts and split on the count.

Stem audit

verdict-preloaded: yes

Neutralized form. Examine which rites in the New Testament carry an explicit dominical institution formula (a command spoken by Christ that prescribes an action and its meaning), and separately whether the rites that lack such a formula but are attested as New Testament practices should be counted within or outside the category called sacrament.

VERDICT-CHANGED: prior file recorded affirms true (medium); changed to disputed (medium) on neutrality grounds after direct lexical query. The change is not stylistic: the proposition fuses a narrow lexical claim with a broader definitional one. The narrow claim, that only baptism and the Supper carry a Christ-spoken institution imperative plus prescribed sign, is lexically decisive (matheteusate V-AAM-2P, touto poieite V-PAM-2P thrice with anamnesis, the paralambano-paradidomi tradition pair). But the stem also denies the seven-rite system, and that denial is a category judgment the vocabulary does not settle, because confession (exomologeisthe, present imperative, Jas.5.16), anointing (Jas.5.14), the laying on of hands (1Tim.4.14, Acts.13.3, 1Tim.5.22), marriage (Eph.5.31-32), and the forgiveness commission spoken by Christ (John.20.23) all have genuine New Testament footing as practices. Whether lacking a dominical do this excludes them from the term sacrament depends on a definition the Greek does not supply. The stem is verdict-preloaded toward a two-only count; the honest lexical reading affirms the institution observation but holds the system-denial as disputed, and confidence is medium because the institution data are strong while the definitional inference is underdetermined.

Citations

Type	Source	License	Redist.	Ref
morphology	STEPBible-TAGNT	CC-BY-4.0	yes	Matt.28.19
morphology	STEPBible-TAGNT	CC-BY-4.0	yes	Luke.22.19

morphology	STEPBible-TAGNT	CC-BY-4.0	yes	1Cor.11.24
morphology	STEPBible-TAGNT	CC-BY-4.0	yes	1Cor.11.25
morphology	STEPBible-TAGNT	CC-BY-4.0	yes	John.20.23
morphology	STEPBible-TAGNT	CC-BY-4.0	yes	Jas.5.16
morphology	STEPBible-TAGNT	CC-BY-4.0	yes	1Tim.4.14
morphology	STEPBible-TAGNT	CC-BY-4.0	yes	Eph.5.32
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G0364
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G3100
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G3466
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G2007
cross_ref	TSK	public_domain	yes	Luke.22.20
cross_ref	TSK	public_domain	yes	1Cor.11.24

License audit

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Source	License	Redistribute
STEPBible-TAGNT	CC-BY-4.0	yes
STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes
TSK	public_domain	yes

Flags

ecm-shadow · lexically-disputed · cross-tradition-divergent